From Prototype to User Validation

We have a prototype. Now we need evidence about how people use it.



1. Introduction	From building a product to learning from users
2. Testing Fundamentals	Understanding observations, interviews, and usability evidence
3. Participant Brief	Preparing the scenario, user task, and instructions
4. Researcher Guide	Defining what to observe, record, and ask
5. Testing Workshop	Preparing and rehearsing the test runs

Learning Outcomes

By the end of today, you should be able to:

- Explain how **observations** and **user interviews** provide complementary evidence about **product usability, user behaviour,** and **perceived value**.
- Design a structured **usability test**, including a realistic user scenario, meaningful task, success criteria, and observation and interview questions.
- Prepare a complete testing session, combining a **functional prototype**, **participant instructions**, and a **researcher guide** to collect useful evidence for product improvement.

Preparing for User Testing

From a working prototype to a structured testing experience.

The Goals

What do we want to learn?

- Identify what we need to validate.
- Define the critical user task.
- Establish what successful completion looks like.

The Participant

What will the tester experience?

- Introduce the product and its context.
- Present a realistic scenario and task.
- Provide clear, neutral instructions and a working prototype.

The Researcher

How will we collect evidence?

- Decide what behaviours to observe.
- Prepare questions for the interview.
- Organise how to record findings.

A meaningful usability test requires a clear purpose, a realistic participant experience, and a structured way to collect evidence.

What Are We Trying to Validate?

User testing should answer specific questions, not simply collect opinions.

Usability

Can users understand and navigate the product?

- Is the interface intuitive?
- Where do users hesitate or get confused?
- Can they proceed without assistance?

Task Success

Can users accomplish their intended goal?

- Do they complete the critical journey?
- Can they reach the expected outcome?
- What prevents successful completion?

Perceived Value

Do users consider the experience useful?

- Does it address a meaningful need?
- What benefits do they recognise?
- Would they consider using it in real life?

We want evidence about what users can do, where they struggle, and whether the solution addresses a meaningful need.

Observations

What users actually do

- Watch how users interact with the prototype.
- Identify hesitation, mistakes, confusion, and workarounds.
- Record whether they complete the task and need assistance.

Mikkeli Chatbot:

User struggles to find the link to the daycare application, even though it is displayed in the chatbot response.

Interviews

what users think and explain

- Ask about difficulties, expectations, and perceived usefulness.
- Explore why users made certain decisions.
- Understand what they expected but did not find.

Mikkeli Chatbot:

User explains that she expected a button labelled "Apply for Daycare" rather than a link embedded in the response.

Observation reveals what happened. Interviews help us understand why it happened.

Poorly Designed Task

Tell users what to do

“Open the chatbot, type 'daycare application', click the official link, and find the application form.”

- Reveals the steps and solution.
- Guides users through the interface.
- Hides potential usability problems.

Well-Designed Task

Give users a situation and goal

“You recently moved to Mikkeli with your family. Your child needs daycare. Use this service to find out how to apply and where to continue.”

- Provides realistic context.
- Defines a meaningful outcome.
- Allows users to find their own way.

A good usability task defines what the user wants to achieve, without explaining how to achieve it.

Participant Brief: What the tester receives?

Prepare the participant to perform a realistic task without teaching them how to use the product.

1. Product Introduction

What is the participant testing?

Briefly introduce the product, its purpose, and any important prototype limitations.

2. User Scenario

What situation should they imagine?

Describe a realistic context, user need, and motivation for using the product.

3. Task Description

What should they accomplish?

Give one clear goal without revealing the steps or where to click.

4. Participation Instructions

How should they approach the test?

Explain the product is being tested, participation is voluntary, and they should proceed naturally without expecting guidance.

Give enough context to proceed, but not so much guidance that you influence their behaviour.

Participant Brief: What the tester receives?

Product introduction	You are about to try an early prototype of a chatbot that helps people find information about Mikkeli city services. We are testing the product, not your abilities. Some functionality may be simulated.
User scenario	Imagine you have recently moved to Mikkeli with your family. Your child needs daycare, and you want to understand how to begin the application process.
Task	Use this service to find out how to apply for daycare and where you should continue next.
Instructions	Please use the prototype as you normally would. You may think aloud if you want, explaining what you are trying to do. Tell us when you feel you have completed the task, or if you would prefer to stop.

A good participant brief helps the tester act naturally, so the team can observe how the product is actually used “in real life”.

Researcher Guide: What Do We Observe?

Prepare a structured observation plan before the participant starts interacting with the prototype.

1. Testing Objective

What specifically we want to learn?

Define the specific usability question your team wants to investigate.

2. Success Criteria

What counts as completing the task?

Establish an observable outcome, including whether assistance was needed.

3. Observation Checklist

What behaviours should we pay attention to?

Record actions, hesitation, confusion, mistakes, workarounds, and task completion.

4. Facilitator Instructions

How should we conduct the session?

Follow a consistent script, avoid coaching, and document when intervention becomes necessary.

Define what success looks like and what evidence to collect before observing users.

Researcher Guide: What Do We Observe?

Objective	Can newcomers independently find the information needed to apply for daycare?
Success criteria	Participant identifies the application process and locates the relevant official information without assistance.
Observation	Where do they click? Do they understand the chatbot's response? Where do they hesitate or ask for help?
Facilitation	Let the participant proceed independently. If they become stuck, use a neutral prompt such as "What would you normally do next?"

The distinction between observation and interpretation:

- **Observation:** "The participant clicked the same link three times."
- **Interpretation:** "The participant did not understand the navigation."

Interview: Understanding the Experience

Good Interview Practices

Encourage honest, useful feedback.

- Ask open-ended questions about the experience.
- Explore difficulties, expectations, and perceived usefulness.
- Follow up on specific behaviours observed during the test.
- Listen without defending or explaining the product.

What to Avoid

Do not influence the answers.

- Leading questions that suggest a preferred answer.
- Yes/no questions that produce little explanation.
- Asking several questions at once.
- Explaining away difficulties or correcting the participant.

Good interviews help us understand the user's perspective, not confirm what we already believe about our product

Asking Better Interview Questions

The way we ask questions influences the quality of the answers we receive.

Avoid Asking	Ask Instead
Was the chatbot easy to use?	What parts of the experience felt easy or difficult?
Did you like our chatbot?	What was your overall impression of the service?
Wouldn't this save you time?	In what situations, if any, would you find this service useful?
Was the application link unclear?	I noticed you returned to the previous page. What were you looking for?

Avoid leading questions that encourage agreement. Ask open-ended questions that encourage explanation. **You want to understand the “why?”**

Workshop: Prepare Your Usability Test

Turn your working prototype into a structured testing experience for next week's peer testing.

Participant Brief

Prepare what the tester receives.

- Introduce the product.
- Describe a realistic user scenario.
- Define one meaningful task.
- Provide neutral instructions.

Researcher Guide

Prepare how you will collect evidence.

- Define objectives and success criteria.
- Identify behaviours to observe.
- Prepare neutral interview questions.

Prototype Dynamics

Make sure the entire test session works.

- Verify the prototype and critical interactions.
- Check simulated functionality.
- Run a test with a teammate to identify and fix problems.

Next week, another team should be able to follow your testing package, use your prototype independently, and provide meaningful evidence about the experience.

Next week's testing dynamics

You are not preparing a demonstration of your product.
You are preparing an experiment to discover whether someone else can use it.

Observation (10min)

Participant reads the brief and attempts the task independently.

Researcher silently observes and records behaviour.

Interview (10min)

Researcher asks questions and record observed difficulties.

Participant explains their experience.

Debrief (10min)

Both identify important findings, and record possible improvements.

Participant provide final constructive comments.

Switch roles and repeat with the other student's prototype.

Total testing activity: 60 minutes